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History

The Mughal Empire and Agrarian Society

Themes in Indian History Part II · Chapter 8 · Peasants, Zamindars and the State (c. 16th–17th Century)

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Official Syllabus Breakdown & Exam Scope

Derived from **Themes in Indian History Part II** (Chapter 8: "Peasants, Zamindars and the State: Agrarian Society and the Mughal Empire c. sixteenth-seventeenth centuries"), this unit tests the structural foundations of medieval rural India, Mughal fiscal administration, agrarian social stratification, and the fiscal records compiled under Emperor Akbar.

Sub-topic	Official syllabus pointer & key NCERT anchors	Skills the questions test
1. Sources & The Ain-i-Akbari	Abu'l-Fazl's **Ain-i-Akbari** (1598); five **daftars** (**Manzil-abadi**, **Sipah-abadi**, **Mulk-abadi**); 17th–18th century revenue records from Gujarat, Maharashtra, and Rajasthan.	Historiographical attribution, text structure, identifying official bias.
2. Peasantry & Crop Production	Peasant terminology (**raiyat**, **asami**, **muzarian**); **Khud-kasht** vs **Pahi-kasht**; **Jins-i-Kamil** (cash crops like cotton and sugarcane); New World crops (tobacco, maize, chillies, tomatoes).	Conceptual differentiation, agricultural classification, historical timelines of crop diffusion.
3. Village Community & Gender	Three constituents (cultivators, headman, panchayat); **Muqaddam** or **Mandal**; **Patwari**; caste panchayats; **Jajmani** system / **watan** in Maharashtra; gendered division of agricultural labor.	Institutional hierarchy, customary law mechanisms, social history analysis.
4. Zamindars & Landed Gentry	Hereditary landed rights; **milkiyat** private estates; collection of imperial taxes for commission; private armies (**qilachas**, cavalry, musketeers); buying and selling of zamindari rights.	Feudal socioeconomic structures, caste composition of landed elites.
5. Land Revenue & Zabti System	Akbar's **Zabti** system; Todar Mal's **Dahsala** (1580); four soil classifications (**Polaj**, **Parauti**, **Chachar**, **Banjar**); **Jama** (assessed) vs **Hasil** (collected); **Amil-guzar** and **Fotadar**.	Fiscal calculation mechanics, administrative terms, revenue official duties.
6. Forests & Silver Monetization	Forest tribes (Bhils, Gonds, Santhals); **peshkash** tribute; transition from shifting to settled cultivation; international trade balance; influx of American silver; silver **rupiya** monetization.	Ecological-state interactions, macro-economic monetary history.

HIGH-YIELD NTA CUET DISTINCTION: JAMA VS HASIL

NTA regularly questions candidates on the distinction between the two stages of Mughal land revenue:

Jama (Theoretical Assessed Revenue Demand) → **Hasil** (Actual Revenue Realized & Collected)

Akbar instructed revenue collectors (**Amil-guzars**) that while **Jama** was determined in cash, cultivators should be permitted to pay in either cash or kind, though cash realization was always actively encouraged.

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Sub-Topic 1: Looking for Sources: The Ain-i-Akbari and Regional Archives

1.1 The Nature of Agrarian Documentation

Because ordinary peasants did not write accounts of their economic existence, historians reconstruct sixteenth- and seventeenth-century agrarian society primarily through state archives. The central source is the **Ain-i-Akbari**, completed in **1598** by **Abu'l-Fazl**, the court historian, grand vizier, and confidant of Emperor Akbar.

The **Ain** was commissioned by Akbar as the third book (**daftar**) of the larger biographical chronicle, the **Akbarnama**. It was explicitly designed to depict the Mughal Empire as a harmonious, efficiently administered realm where diverse communities lived in peace under an enlightened sovereign.

1.2 Structure of the Ain-i-Akbari

The **Ain-i-Akbari** is divided into five constituent books (**daftars**):

1. **Manzil-abadi (First Book)**: Concerns the imperial household, palace maintenance, royal harem, imperial kitchen, and courtly etiquette.
2. **Sipah-abadi (Second Book)**: Covers the military and civil administration, containing biographical sketches of imperial mansabdars, learned scholars, poets, and military officials.
3. **Mulk-abadi (Third Book)**: The most critical fiscal volume. It details the agrarian landscape, containing the **Ain-i-Dahsala** (revenue schedules), soil classifications, statistical tables of the twelve **subas** (provinces), and comprehensive records of **Jama** revenue assessments across Sarkars and Parganas.
4. **Fourth Book**: Deals with the religious, philosophical, literary, scientific, and astrological traditions of the people of India (primarily Hindu traditions), along with customary law and seasons.
5. **Fifth Book**: A compendium of moral sayings, aphorisms, philosophical observations, and advice formulated by Emperor Akbar.

1.3 Regional and Non-Mughal Records

To counterbalance the court-centric perspective of the **Ain-i-Akbari**, modern historians utilize rich seventeenth- and eighteenth-century regional archives:

- **Rajasthan Documents**: Detailed revenue accounts (**arhsattas**) detailing pargana-wise land yields, market prices, and peasant caste distributions.
- **Maharashtra Archives**: Revenue records of the Peshwa period and village **watan** deeds documenting disputes between peasants, village headmen, and hereditary artisans.
- **East India Company Records**: Early English and Dutch mercantile records documenting rural weaving networks, indigo cultivation, and local grain prices.

HISTORIOGRAPHICAL LIMITATIONS OF THE AIN-I-AKBARI

While the **Ain-i-Akbari** is a masterpiece of medieval statistical compilation, it contains distinct limitations that CUET tests:

- **Elite Court Bias**: It views the countryside strictly through the eyes of imperial bureaucrats, portraying peasants as passive recipients of imperial benevolence.
- **Uneven Provincial Coverage**: Detailed statistical tables exist for northern subas (Agra, Delhi, Lahore, Awadh), but fiscal data for Bengal, Orissa, and Gujarat remain sketchy or incomplete.
- **Arithmetic Inaccuracies**: Sir Jadunath Sarkar and subsequent historians discovered arithmetic errors in totals across several suba revenue tables.

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Sub-Topic 2: Peasants and Agricultural Production: Crop Patterns & Technology

2.1 Terminology and Peasant Categories

In Mughal administrative texts, cultivators were referred to by several terms:

- **Raiyat** (plural **riaya**): The common Arabic-Persian term for peasant subjects.
- **Asami**: Cultivators listed as individual revenue-payers in village land registers.
- **Muzarian / Kisan**: General terms for tillers and agriculturalists.

Seventeenth-century sources differentiate between two broad structural categories of peasants:

1. **Khud-kasht**: Resident peasants who lived in the village where they owned land, maintained their own bullocks and plows, and cultivated their ancestral holdings. Their rights were hereditary and generally secure as long as state revenue dues were remitted.
2. **Pahi-kasht**: Non-resident cultivators who cultivated land in villages other than their own on a contractual basis. Peasants became **pahi-kasht** under two circumstances:
   - **By Economic Choice**: Seeking out new villages offering lower revenue rates or fertile uncultivated land.
   - **By Compulsion**: Driven from their home villages by localized droughts, crop failures, pestilence, or oppressive exactions by local zamindars.

2.2 Agricultural Technology and Irrigation

Mughal agriculture was characterized by seasonal crop abundance and labor-intensive cultivation:

- **Irrigation**: While agriculture relied primarily on the monsoon rains, cultivators harnessed artificial irrigation. In northern and western India, the **Persian wheel** (**rahat** or **saqiya**) used geared wooden wheels with earthenware pots to lift water from deep wells.
- **Plowing Tools**: Peasants utilized light wooden plows tipped with an iron coulter, designed to scratch the topsoil without disturbing the moisture-retentive subsoil in arid regions.
- **Cropping Cycles**: Agriculture was anchored on two major cropping cycles:
  - **Kharif**: The autumn harvest, sown at the onset of the summer monsoon (rice, cotton, millets, maize).
  - **Rabi**: The spring harvest, sown in winter and harvested before summer (wheat, barley, mustard, gram).
  - In areas with perennial irrigation, a third summer harvest (**Zaid**) was also cultivated.

2.3 Jins-i-Kamil (Cash Crops) and the Diffusion of New World Crops

The Mughal state actively incentivized the production of **Jins-i-Kamil** (literally "perfect crops"):

- These were commercial cash crops that fetched higher market prices and higher cash revenue assessments for the state treasury.
- Foremost among **Jins-i-Kamil** were **cotton** (cultivated extensively across Gujarat, Malwa, and the Deccan plateau) and **sugarcane** (cultivated in Bengal, Bihar, and the Doab), followed by oilseeds and indigo.

Diffusion of New World Crops (16th–17th Centuries): Through global maritime trade networks established by the Portuguese and European trading companies, crops originating from the Americas entered Indian agriculture:

- **Tobacco**: Introduced by the Portuguese around 1600. It spread so rapidly across the Deccan and northern India that Emperor **Jahangir** issued an imperial decree banning tobacco smoking in **1617** due to public health concerns.
- **Maize (Makka)**: Introduced via Africa and Spain, becoming a major staple in western and central India by the late seventeenth century.
- **Vegetables and Fruits**: Potatoes, tomatoes, green chillies, pineapples (**ananas**), and papayas were all New World cultivars integrated into Indian diets during this era.

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Sub-Topic 3: Rural Social Hierarchy: The Agrarian Pyramid

Rural society in Mughal India was highly stratified, reflecting an intricate hierarchy extending from the imperial revenue collector down to landless menial laborers.

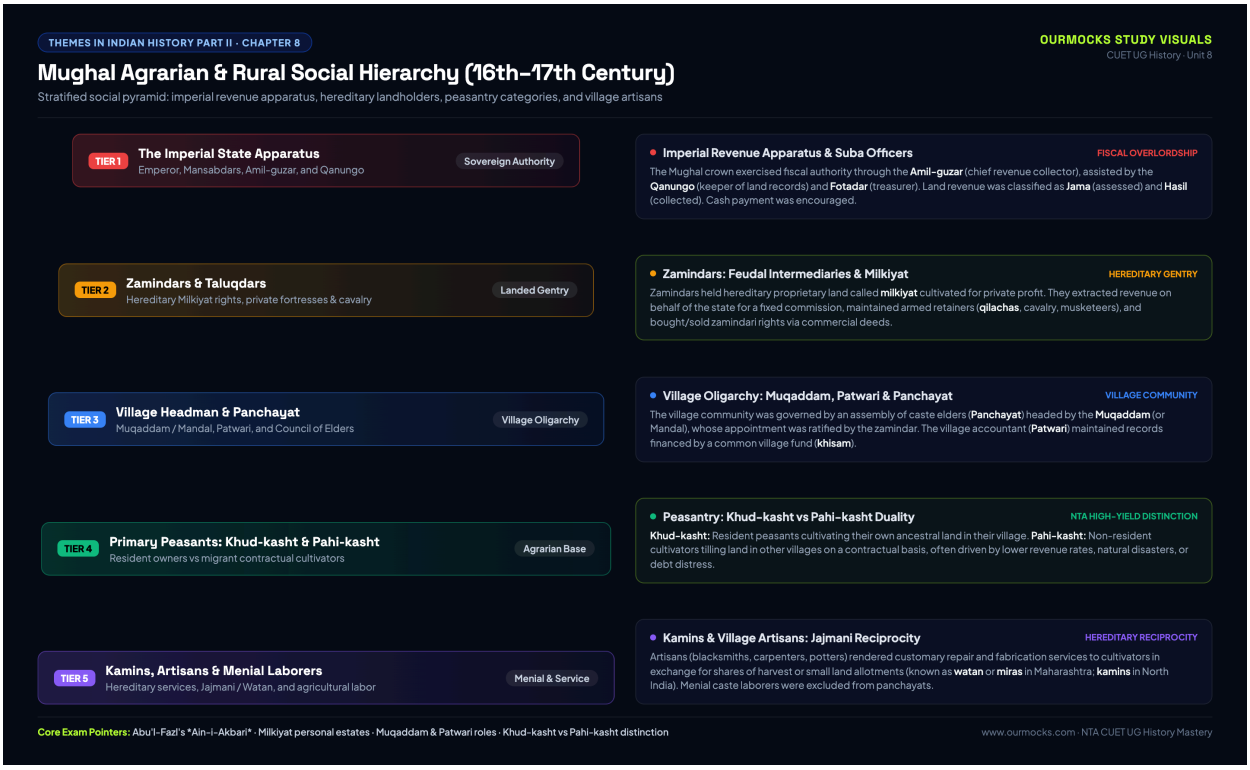


Figure 1: Stratified Social Pyramid of Mughal Agrarian Society

3.1 The Strata of the Agrarian Pyramid

1. **Tier 1 — Imperial State Apparatus**: The Emperor, provincial governors (**Subadars**), district revenue officers (**Amil-guzars**), keepers of land records (**Qanungos**), and treasurers (**Fotadars**).
2. **Tier 2 — Zamindars & Taluqdars**: The landed aristocracy possessing hereditary **milkiyat** lands, controlling private armed retainers, and serving as revenue collectors for the crown.
3. **Tier 3 — Village Oligarchy**: The village headman (**Muqaddam** or **Mandal**), the village accountant (**Patwari**), and the council of upper-caste village elders (**Panchayat**).
4. **Tier 4 — Primary Cultivators**: **Khud-kasht** (resident landholding peasants) and **Pahi-kasht** (migrant contractual peasants).
5. **Tier 5 — Menial Castes & Service Artisans**: **Kamins** (hereditary service providers), leatherworkers (**chamar**), agricultural day-laborers (**majur**), and forest dwellers.

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Sub-Topic 4: The Village Community, Caste Dynamics, and Gender Roles

4.1 The Three Constituents of the Village

NCERT identifies three interdependent constituents that formed the institutional core of the Mughal village community:

1. **The Cultivators**: The broad body of peasant producers responsible for tilling the soil.
2. **The Village Headman (Muqaddam or Mandal)**:

- Chosen by the consensus of the village elders, subject to formal ratification by the local zamindar.
- Held office as long as he enjoyed the confidence of the village elders; could be dismissed by them if he acted arbitrarily.
- Primary function was supervising the preparation of village revenue accounts, assisted by the **Patwari** (village accountant).
- Remunerated through a percentage of collected revenue or rent-free agricultural land.

3. **The Village Panchayat**:
   - An oligarchic assembly representing the respected elders of dominant agricultural castes.
   - Subordinated or menial caste groups and agricultural laborers had no representation in the general village panchayat.
   - Functioned as a local court: settled property boundaries, adjudicated contract disputes, and enforced caste norms.
   - Possessed the power to levy fines or order the ultimate social sanction: temporary or permanent expulsion from the caste/village.
   - Financed through a common village financial pool (**khisam** or **kholah**), which also funded public festivals, hospitality for inspecting revenue officials, and famine relief.

4.2 Caste Panchayats and Village Artisans

In addition to the general village panchayat, each caste (**jati**) maintained its own **Caste Panchayat**:

- Handled domestic matters, validated marriages, arbitrated inheritance disputes, and ensured ritual purity codes were observed.
- In civil disputes between different castes, appeals could be made to the state qazi, but the decision of the caste panchayat was usually final within the community.

Village Artisans and the Jajmani / Watan System: Village self-sufficiency was mediated through institutionalized service reciprocity:

- Specialized artisans—blacksmiths, carpenters, potters, barbers, and leatherworkers—provided tools and services to cultivators.
- In return, cultivators compensated artisans through customary shares of the harvest (**remuneration in kind**), or through allotments of cultivable land.
- In Maharashtra, these hereditary artisan rights and landholdings were known as **watan** or **miras**, which were legally protected, alienable, and inheritable.
- In northern India, this system of hereditary service exchange was termed the **jajmani** system by colonial anthropologists.

4.3 Women in the Agrarian Economy

Women played an indispensable, labor-intensive role in agrarian production:

- **Labor Division**: While men plowed and tilled the fields, women performed sowing, weeding, harvesting, threshing, and winnowing.
- **Commercial & Domestic Labor**: Women participated extensively in artisan production, including spinning cotton yarn, cleaning wool, kneading clay for pottery, and marketing produce in local bazaars.

- **Social Vulnerabilities**: High mortality rates among women resulted from inadequate nutrition, frequent pregnancies, and lack of medical assistance. Peasant and artisan households faced chronic female labor shortages.
- **Customary Rights**: Unlike upper-caste urban women who observed strict seclusion (**purdah**), peasant women possessed greater mobility. In many peasant communities, widow remarriage (**dharicha** or **karewa**) was socially sanctioned. Women in landed families occasionally inherited zamindari rights, signed revenue deeds, and acted as independent heads of households.

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Sub-Topic 5: The Zamindars: Feudal Retainers, Milkiyat, and Military Might

5.1 Nature of Zamindari Rights

The **Zamindars** were hereditary landed intermediaries who occupied a pivotal position between the imperial state and the agrarian peasantry:

- **Non-Cultivating Proprietors**: They enjoyed social and economic privileges by virtue of their exalted caste status (predominantly Rajputs, Brahmans, and dominant regional castes).
- **Milkiyat (Personal Lands)**: Zamindars held extensive personal estates termed **milkiyat** ("property"). These lands were cultivated for the personal profit of the zamindar, typically using hired agricultural laborers (**majurs**) or tenant sharecroppers.
- **Revenue Intermediaries**: On behalf of the Mughal state, zamindars collected revenue from the villages comprising their **taaluqa** or estate. For this service, they were remunerated with a percentage of the collected revenue (usually ranging between 10% and 25%), known as **nankar** or **malikana**.

5.2 Military Retainers and Castles

The power of the zamindars was fortified by substantial private military forces:

- **Private Fortresses**: Abu'l-Fazl records that zamindars across the empire maintained fortified strongholds (**qilachas**).
- **Armed Retainers**: According to the **Ain-i-Akbari**, the combined military retainers of all zamindars across the empire exceeded **3.8 lakh cavalry**, **42 lakh infantry**, **1,800 elephants**, **4,200 cannons**, and thousands of river transport boats.
- **State Bargaining**: When the Mughal center was strong, zamindars remitted revenue regularly; when central authority weakened, zamindars utilized their private armies to withhold tribute and assert local autonomy.

5.3 Commercialization of Zamindari Rights

During the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries, zamindari rights underwent rapid commercialization:

- Rights could be bought, mortgaged, and sold through registered legal deeds (**kabalas**).

- Upwardly mobile peasant and merchant castes (such as Jats, Ahirs, and Khatris) utilized accumulated commercial wealth to purchase zamindari estates, altering the traditional caste composition of regional landed elites.

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Sub-Topic 6: The Mughal Land Revenue System: Zabti, Dahsala, and Fiscal Flow

The fiscal lifeblood of the Mughal Empire was land revenue (**mal**). Under Emperor Akbar, the revenue administration was completely overhauled by his Finance Minister (**Diwan**), **Raja Todar Mal**.

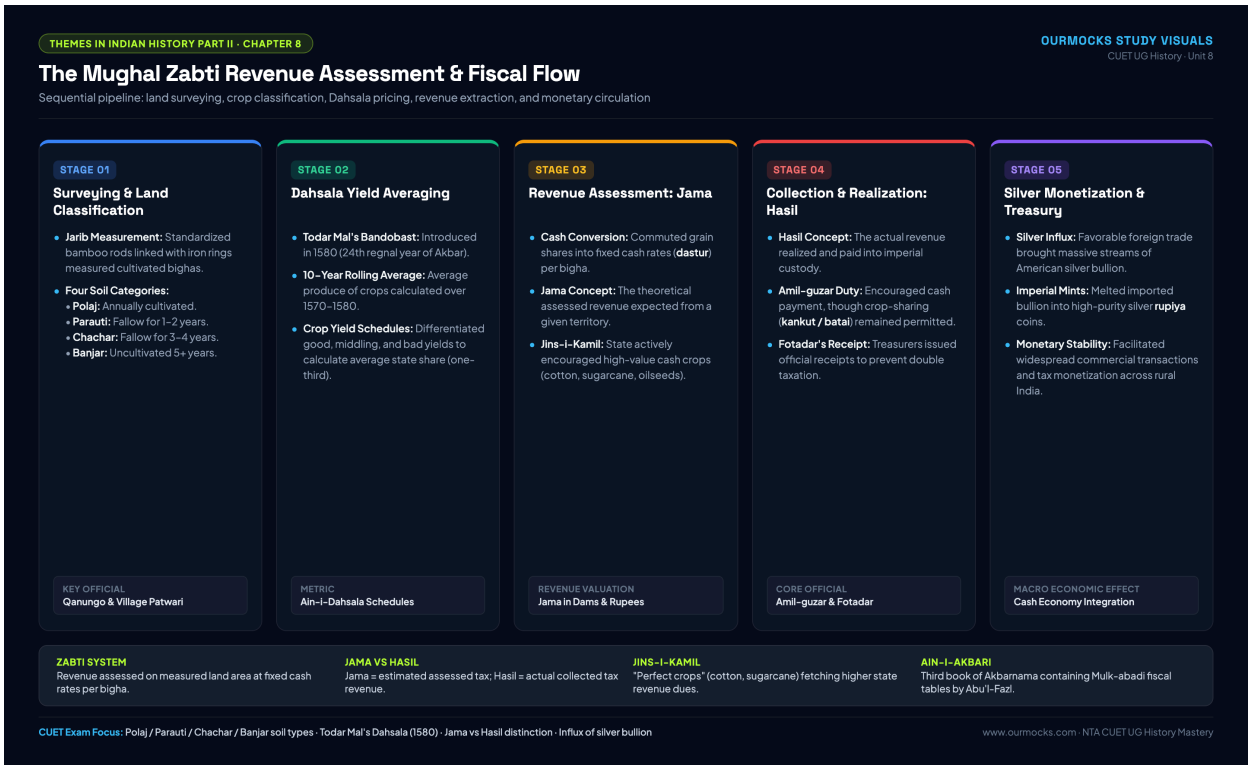


Figure 2: The Mughal Zabti Revenue Assessment and Fiscal Pipeline

6.1 The Zabti System and Todar Mal's Bandobast

The **Zabti system** was the standard method of revenue assessment established across the core provinces of the empire (Agra, Delhi, Lahore, Malwa, and Awadh):

- **Measurement** (Paimaish): Every cultivable plot of land was surveyed using a standardized measuring rod made of bamboo linked with iron rings (**tanab** or **jarib**), replacing the older rope measure that expanded in wet weather.
- **Unit of Area**: The standard unit of land measurement was the **bigha** (equaling 60 × 60 imperial yards or **gaz-i-Ilahi**).
- **Dahsala System (1580 CE)**: Introduced in the 24th regnal year of Akbar (1580) by Raja Todar Mal. Under this system:
  - The state calculated the average produce of each crop over the preceding ten years (1570–1580 CE).
  - The state's share was fixed at **one-third** (33.3%) of this ten-year average yield.

- The grain demand was commuted into cash rates based on regional price schedules (**dastur-al-amal**), allowing cultivators to know their precise fiscal obligations per bigha in advance.

6.2 Land Classification by Cultivation Frequency

The **Ain-i-Akbari** outlines four distinct classifications of agricultural land, reflecting soil fertility and cultivation frequency:

Land Category	Fallow Frequency	Revenue Treatment & Cultivation Status
Polaj	Never fallow	Continuously cultivated every year in successive cycles; pays full revenue annually.
Parauti	Fallow for 1–2 years	Left fallow temporarily to recover natural soil fertility; pays full revenue when cultivated.
Chachar	Fallow for 3–4 years	Land that has remained fallow for three to four consecutive years; assessed at concessional rates upon reclamation.
Banjar	Fallow for 5+ years	Uncultivated wasteland for five years or more; assessed at progressive, nominal rates to encourage peasant clearing and reclamation.

6.3 Alternative Revenue Systems

Where the rigorous surveying requirements of the **Zabti** system could not be enforced, older methods persisted:

- **Kankut (Appraisal)**: **Kan** means grain, and **kut** means estimate. The standing crop field was inspected, and the total yield was estimated by experienced revenue appraisers.
- **Batai / Bhaoli (Crop Sharing)**: Grain was harvested, threshed, and divided physically into shares in the presence of state agents.
- **Khet-Batai**: The field was marked out and divided before harvesting.
- **Lang-Batai**: The harvest was gathered into heaps after threshing and divided between the cultivator and the state.

6.4 Key Imperial Revenue Officials

- **Amil-guzar**: The chief revenue collector of the **sarkar** (district), responsible for surveying, assessing, and ensuring the timely collection of **Hasil**.
- **Qanungo**: The hereditary district officer maintaining historical land records, productivity schedules, and boundary registers.
- **Fotadar / Khazandar**: The imperial treasurer of the pargana, responsible for receiving coin payments, testing coin purity, and issuing official receipts.
- **Bitikchi**: The head revenue scribe who maintained day-to-day land measurement entries and assessment registers.

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Sub-Topic 7: Forests, Tribal Societies, and the Flow of Silver

7.1 Forest Dwellers (Jangal) and State Ecology

Forests covered substantial parts of the Mughal subcontinent, termed **jangal** or **kandhar**:

- **Forest Tribes**: Populated by tribal communities including the **Bhils** (western India), **Gonds** (central India), **Santhals** and **Mundas** (eastern plateau), and **Ahoms** (Assam).
- **Economic Activities**: Forest dwellers engaged in shifting cultivation (**jhum**), hunting, gathering wild honey, lac, resin, and charcoal.
- **Imperial Penetration**: The Mughal state did not leave forests untouched:
  - **Hunting Expeditions (**Shikar**)**: The emperor personally led massive hunting expeditions through border forests, serving both as military exercises and opportunities to receive regional tribal chiefs.
  - **Peshkash**: Tribal chiefs paid tribute to the Mughal emperor in the form of wild captured **elephants**, valuable timber, honey, and aromatic gums.
  - **Commercial Integration**: Commercial demand for forest goods (such as lac used for sealing wax and dyes) drew forest communities into cash market networks, accelerating the gradual transition of tribal groups into settled agricultural castes.

7.2 The Flow of Silver and Monetary Integration

During the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries, the Mughal Empire became deeply integrated into the emergent global trade economy:

- **Balance of Trade**: India maintained a heavily favorable balance of trade with Europe, the Middle East, and Southeast Asia, exporting vast quantities of fine cotton textiles, silk, indigo, pepper, and spices.
- **Silver Bullion Influx**: European merchants (Portuguese, Dutch, and English) possessed few manufactured goods that Indian markets desired; they consequently paid for Indian exports in **silver bullion** and coins extracted from the mines of Spanish America (such as Potosí).
- **The Silver Rupee (Rupiya)**: Imported foreign silver flowed into royal Mughal mints (**karkhanas**), where it was melted down and re-minted into standardized, high-purity silver **rupiyas**.
- **Economic Impact**: This unprecedented influx of silver provided the currency liquidity necessary for the complete monetization of the **Zabti** land revenue system, enabling millions of peasants across northern and western India to pay imperial taxes in cash.

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Sub-Topic 8: Comprehensive Chapter Synthesizer Mindmap

To consolidate all eight dimensions of Chapter 8—primary sources, peasant duality, village oligarchies, zamindari estates, Dahsala assessment, ecological relations, and monetary integration—the structural mindmap below provides the master review architecture:

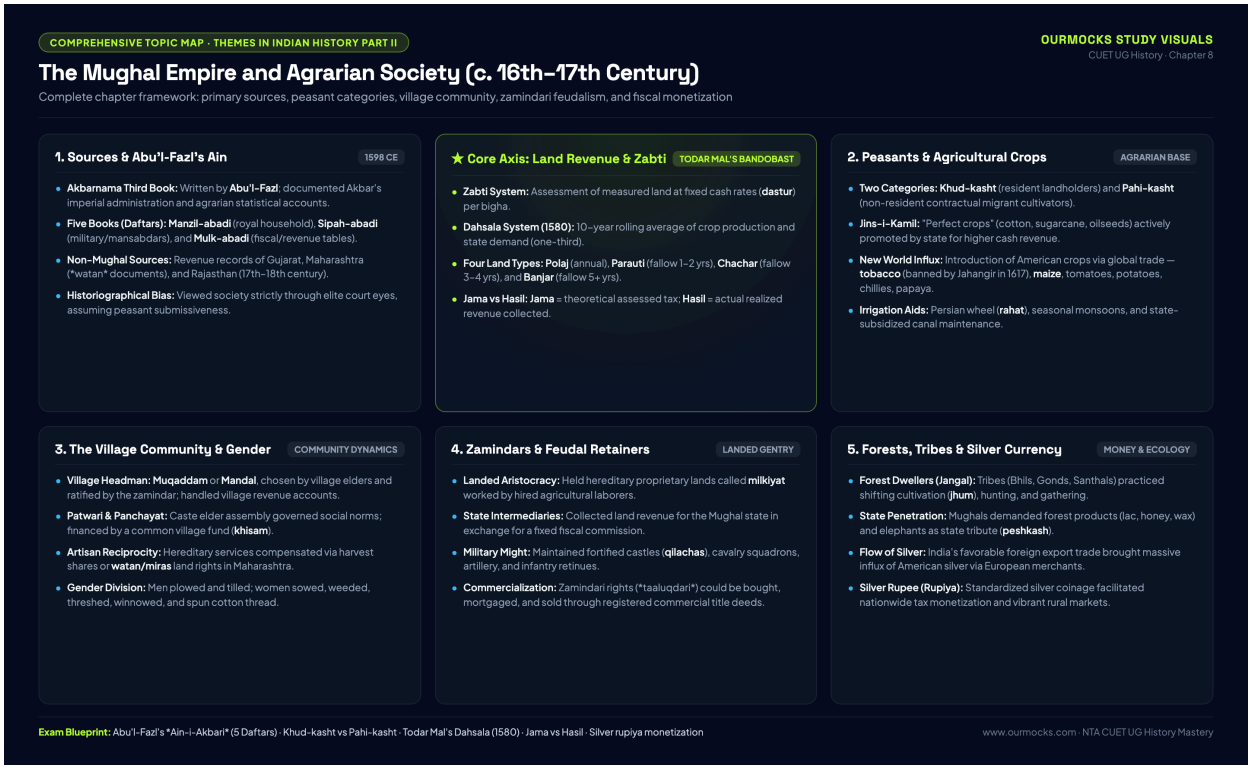


Figure 3: Comprehensive Synthesizer Mindmap: Mughal Agrarian Economy and Rural Statecraft

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High-Yield Chronology & Nomenclature Reference

Year / Period	Historical Milestone & Administrative Measure
1526 CE	Babur establishes Mughal rule; observes northern Indian irrigation and **rahat** (Persian wheel) in **Baburnama**.
1540–1545 CE	Sher Shah Suri introduces standardized land measurement and early crop rate schedules (**ray**).
1556 CE	Accession of Akbar; initial experimentation with regional price schedules under Muzaffar Khan Turbati.
1580 CE	Promulgation of the **Ain-i-Dahsala** (Ten-Year Settlement) by Finance Minister Raja Todar Mal.
1598 CE	Completion of the **Ain-i-Akbari** by Abu'l-Fazl (third book of the **Akbarnama**).
c. 1600 CE	Introduction of tobacco and maize into India by Portuguese maritime traders.
1617 CE	Emperor Jahangir issues an imperial decree prohibiting tobacco smoking due to health damages.
1658–1707 CE	Reign of Aurangzeb; growing strain between imperial revenue demands and zamindari insurrections.

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High-Yield NTA CUET Practice Questions (15 MCQs)

Q1. The celebrated statistical and administrative work **Ain-i-Akbari** forms which book of Abu'l-Fazl's **Akbarnama**?

(A) First Book **(B)** Second Book
(C) Third Book **(D)** Fifth Book

Sol. Q1. The **Ain-i-Akbari** constitutes the **Third Book** (**daftar**) of the **Akbarnama**. The first book deals with Akbar's ancestors, and the second chronicles Akbar's reign up to the 46th regnal year.

Answer: (C)

Q2. Which book (daftar) of the **Ain-i-Akbari** contains statistical revenue tables, soil classifications, and provincial (**suba**) accounts?

(A) Manzil-abadi **(B)** Sipah-abadi
(C) Mulk-abadi **(D)** Dahsala-abadi

Sol. Q2. The **Mulk-abadi** (Third Book of the **Ain**) is the fiscal and administrative volume containing the revenue schedules, soil categories, and suba-wise statistical accounts.

Answer: (C)

Q3. In Mughal agrarian society, resident peasants who cultivated their own ancestral land within their home village were termed:

(A) Pahi-kasht **(B)** Khud-kasht
(C) Muzarian **(D)** Asami

Sol. Q3. Khud-kasht were resident cultivators who lived in the village where they owned and tilled their land. **Pahi-kasht** were non-resident contractual cultivators tilling land in other villages.

Answer: (B)

Q4. Under the **Zabti** land classification system, land that was cultivated continuously every year and never left fallow was called:

(A) Parauti **(B)** Banjar
(C) Polaj **(D)** Chachar

Sol. Q4. Polaj was land that was cultivated annually for each harvest and was never permitted to lie fallow.

Answer: (C)

Q5. The **Dahsala** system of land revenue assessment was introduced in 1580 under Akbar by which prominent minister?

(A) Abu'l-Fazl
(B) Bairam Khan
(C) Raja Man Singh
(D) Raja Todar Mal

Sol. Q5. Raja Todar Mal, Akbar's Finance Minister (**Diwan**), formulated the **Dahsala** system in 1580 (24th regnal year of Akbar), basing revenue demand on the 10-year average produce and prices.

Answer: (D)

Q6. Which of the following agricultural commodities were designated as **Jins-i-Kamil** (perfect crops) by the Mughal state?

(A) Coarse millets and pulses
(B) Cotton and sugarcane
(C) Barley and gram
(D) Rice and wheat only

Sol. Q6. Jins-i-Kamil ("perfect crops") referred to high-value cash crops such as cotton and sugarcane, which brought higher revenue to the state treasury.

Answer: (B)

Q7. Which Mughal Emperor banned the smoking and consumption of tobacco in 1617 CE?

(A) Akbar
(B) Jahangir
(C) Shah Jahan
(D) Aurangzeb

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Sol. Q7. Tobacco was introduced into India around 1600. Noting its addictive nature and harmful effects on public health, Emperor Jahangir banned its consumption in 1617.

Answer: (B)

Q8. Match List-I (Soil Category) with List-II (Fallow Duration): (a) Polaj — 1. Fallow for 5+ years (b) Parauti — 2. Continuously cultivated (c) Chachar — 3. Fallow for 1–2 years (d) Banjar — 4. Fallow for 3–4 years

(A) (a)-2, (b)-3, (c)-4, (d)-1
(B) (a)-3, (b)-2, (c)-1, (d)-4
(C) (a)-2, (b)-4, (c)-3, (d)-1
(D) (a)-1, (b)-3, (c)-4, (d)-2

Sol. Q8. Polaj = annually cultivated (2); Parauti = fallow 1–2 years (3); Chachar = fallow 3–4 years (4); Banjar = uncultivated 5 or more years (1).

Answer: (A)

Q9. The personal, private proprietary lands held by zamindars in Mughal India were known as:

(A) Taaluqa **(B)** Milkiyat
(C) Watan **(D)** Inam

Sol. Q9. Zamindars' personal agricultural lands cultivated for private profit were called **milkiyat** ("property"). These lands were often tilled by hired laborers.

Answer: (B)

Q10. In Maharashtra, hereditary land and service rights held by village artisans and village officials were designated as:

(A) Jajmani **(B)** Watan
(C) Khisam **(D)** Nankar

Sol. Q10. In the Deccan and Maharashtra, hereditary holdings and occupational claims were termed **watan** (or **miras**), which were alienable and legally inheritable.

Answer: (B)

Q11. What was the primary function of the **Amil-guzar** in the Mughal district (**sarkar**) administration?

(A) Maintaining law and order and policing **(B)** Chief revenue collector and assessment officer
(C) Auditing judicial cases and religious endowments **(D)** Commanding district military garrisons

Sol. Q11. The **Amil-guzar** was the district revenue collector whose duty was to survey fields, calculate revenue assessments, and ensure the realization of taxes from cultivators.

Answer: (B)

Q12. Which of the following New World crops was NOT introduced into India during the sixteenth or seventeenth centuries?

(A) Tobacco **(B)** Maize
(C) Green chillies **(D)** Sugarcane

Sol. Q12. Sugarcane is indigenous to India and has been cultivated since antiquity. Tobacco, maize, green chillies, potatoes, and tomatoes were New World crops introduced via European maritime trade.

Answer: (D)

Q13. In the Mughal revenue terminology, the difference between **Jama** and **Hasil** refers to the distinction between:

(A) Tax paid in cash and tax paid in grain
(B) Assessed revenue demand and actual revenue collected
(C) Central treasury revenue and provincial governor's cut
(D) Agricultural tax and transit customs duties

Sol. Q13. **Jama** represented the assessed theoretical revenue demand, whereas **Hasil** denoted the actual revenue realized and collected by the state.

Answer: (B)

Q14. The village accountant who maintained village land records and assisted the Muqaddam was called:

(A) Qanungo
(B) Patwari
(C) Fotadar
(D) Chaudhuri

Sol. Q14. The **Patwari** was the village accountant. The **Qanungo** performed a similar record-keeping function at the higher pargana or district level.

Answer: (B)

Q15. How did the massive expansion of Mughal foreign trade during the 16th and 17th centuries affect the domestic economy?

(A) Caused a severe deflation due to grain hoarding
(B) Led to the complete abandonment of cash taxes
(C) Resulted in a massive influx of American silver bullion, monetizing the economy
(D) Depleted the imperial gold reserves to pay European merchants

Sol. Q15. India's large trade surplus in textiles and spices brought a continuous influx of European and American silver bullion. This silver was minted into **rupiyas**, monetizing rural revenue transactions.

Answer: (C)

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Wrong-Answer Clinic (CUET Traps & Common Misconceptions)

Common Mistake / Confusion	NTA Examination Trap	Correct Historical Fact & NCERT Clarification
Confusing **Khud-kasht** and **Pahi-kasht**	Asserting that Khud-kasht were landless la-	**Khud-kasht** were resident landowning cultivators. **Pahi-kasht** were non-resident

Common Mistake / Confusion	NTA Examination Trap	Correct Historical Fact & NCERT Clarification
	borers and Pahi-kasht were landlords.	peasants cultivating land in other villages on a contractual basis.
Assuming the **Ain** covers all Mughal India equally	Believing the statistical tables are uniform across all provinces.	Detailed statistical tables exist primarily for northern subas (Agra, Delhi, Lahore). Bengal, Orissa, and Gujarat lack detailed field-level revenue data in the **Ain**.
Equating **Jama** with **Hasil**	Treating the two terms as interchangeable synonyms for revenue.	**Jama** was the estimated **assessed** tax demand. **Hasil** was the actual **collected** revenue realized in the imperial treasury.
Assuming New World Crops are ancient Indian cultivars	Believing tobacco, maize, chillies, or potatoes were mentioned in ancient Sanskrit texts.	These crops originated in the Americas and were brought to India in the 16th–17th centuries through Portuguese and European maritime commerce.
Confusing **Amil-guzar** with **Qanungo**	Assigning the record-keeping role of the Qanungo to the Amil-guzar.	The **Amil-guzar** was the executive revenue collector. The **Qanungo** was the hereditary archivist and keeper of land records.

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